

themselves since the Counter Strike days were giving the new kid in town a chance. Marzil, Psy Gaming, Antidote, Ankit Panth and others had adopted Valorant after the CS:GO scene in India had been butchered because of a certain player who had been accused and found guilty of cheating.

As people received new found inspiration from these people, it rejuvenated a passion for eSports in the country.

Something Bigger

As Valorant continued to grow, so did the demand for more and more pro play. Initially, it was only NODWIN Gaming that had hosted one of the biggest tournaments in the country, more and more Tournament Organisers started to take form.

One of the earliest and most popular Tournament Organisers to take hold in Valorant was The Esports Club, it popularised the Gauntlet format of tournaments and was THE tournament to be a part of if you were a Pro or wanted to be one.

The biggest teams of the nation back then, namely Global eSports, Velocity Gaming, Reckoning eSports, and the likes were always found to be participating, giving the public a number of reasons to watch and earning more fans in the process.

The Esports Club continued to grow into one of the boutique Tournament Organisers in India today and still hosts numerous tournaments.

The biggest name today though, is that of Skyesports, an organisation which popularised the League format of tournaments by doing things the way the IPL does.

Though the teams formed were obviously only exclusive to the tournament itself and did not bind the players together for anything outside of it, seeing such an interesting format come into play was something that the people loved to watch.

Very soon, Skyesports developed into one of the biggest TOs that India currently has, even extending their reach to Riot Games themselves.

It was only recently that we saw Valorant take the Global LAN stage back in



The Esports Club was one of the first organisers to make it big in Indian Valorant

2021 for Masters Reykjavik and it didn't take time for Skyesports to follow in the footsteps for the same.

They organised India's very first LAN in the city of Mumbai named the Skyesports Souvenir which saw the participation of only four invited teams in order to keep the virus at bay and yet, it was still one of the most historic events for Valorant eSports in India.

The Souvenir served as a sort of green flag for all other TOs that it was now viable to actually host a LAN again and this time, with much more participation from the people.

Skyesports continued to host tournaments both online as well as on LAN including the Skyesports Champions Series whose winners were to get a slot in the APAC Regional Qualifiers for the Valorant Champions Tour Masters Copenhagen which concluded this month itself.



Skyesports continues to be one of the biggest TOs in India

Of course Valorant wasn't the only game seeing some action though, the banned prince of Indian eSports had made a return but this time with a different name and a few small changes.

Battlegrounds Mobile India saw almost the same amount of popularity as it had before, if not, more.

It was in the month of June of this year itself that BGMI also saw its first LAN ever after the pandemic hosted by NODWIN Gaming and even though an audience wasn't allowed, it was as magnificent as you would hope.

With the event being streamed directly on National Television on Star Sports, it surely gained a lot of traction from people across the nation who had never even known that eSports existed.

Seeing the success of these events and the rising number of tournaments being hosted by numerous different



Battlegrounds Mobile brought back the craze for PUBG

TOs, it's only a matter of time before things start taking a turn for the better and the curve starts going up again.

What does it mean for the future?

Of course, this isn't the biggest that eSports can be and this is definitely not where it's going to stop. With things slowly returning to normal, we can hope to see the popularity of Gaming and eSports go up once again and LANs are going to be one of the binding pillars contributing to the growth of the field.

There are obviously other games that are considered under the eSports umbrella and are slowly gaining more and more popularity with the gamers across the country such as Apex Legends, which only recently got its mobile version as well, League of Legends which already has a small but very active scene in the country, and of course Dota 2, which has been the OG eSport of India but is currently not in the spotlight.

These games are sure to receive more and more traction in the future as eSports continues to grow in India and it is only a matter of time before things go big once again. *